Local grammars and diachronic speech act analysis

A case study of apology in the history of American English

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This paper proposes a method that is designed to facilitate diachronic speech act analysis. The proposed method draws on the corpus linguistic concept of local grammar – an approach which seeks to account for, not the whole of a language, but one meaning or function only. Local grammar descriptions capture both formal and semantic regularities of speech act realisations, and local grammars offer a more reliable way to quantify speech act realisations across time. It is particularly in this respect that it is argued that a local grammar approach can be useful for diachronic speech act studies, which is demonstrated subsequently by tracing one particular speech act, namely "apology", in a sample of the Corpus of Historical American English (COHA).

Keywords: American English, apology, diachronic speech act analysis, local grammar, speech acts

1. Introduction

This paper is primarily methodological: I propose a local grammar approach (see Section 2 for more discussion) to facilitate diachronic speech act analysis and demonstrate subsequently the proposed method with a case study of apology in the history of American English. The study is situated within the field of historical corpus pragmatics, a research tradition which uses corpus linguistic concepts and/or methods to trace the diachronic development of pragmatic units (Jucker and Taavitsainen 2014a). Among pragmatic phenomena, diachronic speech act analysis has probably attracted most attention. Kohnen (2015: 52) similarly notes that "[d]iacrhonic speech act analysis has, without doubt, become a major field

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of research within the fairly young discipline of historical pragmatics". The reason for this may be that "speech act analysis could serve as a ground-breaker towards a pragmatic history of the English language" (Taavitsainen and Jucker 2008: 2).

Indeed, there has been a plethora of diachronic studies investigating different speech acts in the history of English. Earlier studies include Jucker and Taavitsainen (2000) who investigate insults in Old English, and Jacobsson (2002) who explores thanking in Early Modern English. Taavitsainen and Jucker's (2007) and Kohnen's (2007) contributions to the collected volume *Methods in Historical Pragmatics* (Fitzmaurice and Taavitsainen [eds] 2007) are also representative ones. More notably, Jucker and Taavitsainen (2008a) offer a valuable collection of studies which investigate various speech acts in the history of English, contributing substantially to diachronic speech act analysis. In addition, Jucker and Taavitsainen (2014b), using the Corpus of Historical American English (COHA), examine the diachronic development of compliments.

Archer (2010) and Kohnen (2015) have presented instructive and comprehensive overviews of recent diachronic investigations into speech acts. I will not, therefore, attempt to provide a detailed review of previous studies. I will, however, discuss three methodological issues which appear to have not yet been carefully considered and, consequently, adequately addressed. The first two issues might appear to be trivial but are worth considering: one relates to comparability. While it has been widely agreed that historical pragmatics relies heavily upon corpus data (Fitzmaurice and Taavitsainen [eds] 2007), previous studies tend to compare data retrieved from different corpora. This might involve two problems. One is that different corpora are compiled according to different criteria and, in consequence, different corpora do not necessarily comprise the same types of texts, nor the same proportion of each text type. These data might therefore be potentially incomparable. Kohnen (2000), for example, faces this problem. His investigation of (non-)performative uses of speech act verbs is based on data drawn from the Old English part of the *Helsinki Corpus*, the *London Lund Corpus* and the *London-Oslo/Bergen Corpus*. A further problem is that, even if one is comparing corpora comprised of apparently the same genres or text types, those genres or text types may have shifted. For example, a trial proceeding from the sixteenth century or early seventeenth century may not be at all like a trial proceeding from the twentieth century. This should also be taken into account in diachronic studies.

The second issue is: do diachronic studies have to cover a consecutive time span? Taavitsainen and Jucker (2008: 3) argue that "[d]iachronic speech act analysis aims at charting the manifestation of speech acts through various periods by comparing two or more synchronic descriptions". However, while being aware that it is challenging to compile a corpus which contains texts

produced, say, from the fourteenth- to the twenty-first century, I would suggest that it is desirable that the periods during which a given speech act is examined are consecutive, because comparing synchronic descriptions of that speech act in different periods is more like a contrastive study, and not diachronic *per se*. Jucker and Taavitsainen's (2014b) recent study is a good case in point, and avoids this problem. Their investigation into compliments is based on data drawn from COHA which consists of texts decade by decade, starting from the 1810s and ending in the 2000s (see Davies 2012a,b) for a detailed discussion about the design, creation and annotation of COHA).

The third issue is more serious and is the one that this study primarily aims to address. It relates to the quantification of speech act realisations across time. Specifically, what previous studies usually do is to analyse a given utterance in terms of the speech act it realises, and then count the frequency and/or distribution of each speech act and its realisations across contexts or time periods. For example, previous studies would count utterances such as "sorry", "I'm sorry", "sorry about that" as apologies realised by *sorry*. From a local grammar perspective, however, these utterances instantiate different semantic patterns and should thus be regarded as different realisations of apology, as I shall discuss further in Section 2. The problem previous studies face, then, is that they have moved directly from realisation forms to pragmatic speech functions with little consideration of the semantics of those forms; and as such they only capture regularities in formal realisations but not the underlying semantic regularities. The implication is that speech act realisations may have not been reliably quantified and so, consequently, observations drawn by analysing formal realisations might be potentially questionable. This indicates the necessity of exploring alternative method(s) to quantify speech act realisations across time. In this study, I will demonstrate that the local grammar approach can be one candidate.

Moreover, as noted in Taavitsainen and Fitzmaurice (2007: 18), "[t]he difficulties in applying corpus methods are most manifest with macrolevel questions like the diachronic development of speech acts". The main motivation for this study is therefore methodological, with a view to exploiting the strengths of corpus linguistic methods in diachronic speech act analysis. To that end, I propose a method which is designed for corpus-based diachronic investigation into speech acts. The proposed method draws on the corpus linguistic concept of local grammar (see Section 2), thus partly responding to Kohnen's (2015: 76) suggestion that "[i]f new paradigms of analysis in speech act theory should evolve, these could certainly be taken up in a corpus-based analysis". The proposed method is demonstrated subsequently by tracing one particular speech act (namely, apology) in the history of American English. What this approach is, and why and how it can be applied to diachronic speech act analysis, will be discussed in detail below.

2. Local grammar

The concept of local grammar has been discussed comprehensively elsewhere (Su 2017, 2018; Hunston and Su 2019; Su and Wei 2018). Briefly, local grammar is an alternative approach, as opposed to general grammars, to linguistic analysis and explanation. Each local grammar is a grammar which seeks to account for, not the whole of a language, but one meaning or function only (Hunston 2002: 178). It takes into account the functions that language fulfils in social contexts. Each local grammar is in essence a functional account of language used in a particular semantic or pragmatic domain. A local grammar analysis therefore involves the identification of functional labels (i.e., local grammar terminology) within the specific context of the chosen meaning or function, and then the mapping of the labels/terminologies identified onto stretches of discourses that are associated with that meaning or function. For clarity's sake, "function" here is used in its general sense, referring to pragmatic or communicative functions (e.g., request, apology and thanking); "functional labels" are the terminologies used in local grammar analyses (e.g., *Apologiser, Apologising*, see below). To avoid confusion, I will use "local grammar terminology" to refer to the (functional) label hereafter.

Since local grammars involve the mapping of local grammar terminologies onto formal elements, an essential step in local grammar research is to identify a set of terminologies that can be used for the analysis. With regard to the identification of such terminologies, I suggest two guiding principles. One is termed the Principle of Transparency, meaning that the terminologies used for a local grammar analysis should: (1) be proposed within the specific context of that chosen meaning or function, and (2) explicitly reflect the discoursal or pragmatic function of the element being analysed. In the case of speech act studies, "the selection of local grammar terminology is justified by the speech act being employed" (Hunston and Su 2019: 572), which further helps to enhance the transparency of the terminologies. The other principle is that of Economy, referring to the tendency of using a limited number of local grammar terminologies to achieve a relatively general and comprehensive description of language in use. An example to illustrate this is the label "Specification" which I use in this study (see Section 4 and also Su and Wei 2018). I used "Specification" to analyse those elements which specify the offence/reason for an apology or for forgiveness-seeking. Types of offences, as discussed in Deutschmann (2003: 64), might be related to "accidents", "mistake and misunderstandings", "breach of expectations", "lack of consideration", "talk offences", "social gaffes", "requests", "hearing offences" and "offences involving breach of consensus". One may of course give each of them a terminology in the analysis. The problem, however, is that it will unnecessarily result in a large number of such terminologies and complicate the analysis. Conforming

to the Principle of Economy allows the researcher to avoid this problem. Overall, the two principles guide the identification of local grammar terminologies, which further helps to achieve a description of the realisations of the targeted speech act at an appropriate level of both generality and granularity.

At this point, it is necessary to mention that, while previous studies have also discussed the semantics of some elements (e.g., "Offender", "Intensifier") in speech act utterances (e.g., Aijmer 1996; Deutschmann 2003), it appears that they have not systematically considered the semantics of speech act utterance units. In contrast, local grammars offer an adequate account of each utterance unit which has a pragmatic meaning, identifying a limited yet systematic set of terminologies for the analyses (Su 2017, 2018). This in turn contributes to the adequacy of the description of speech act realisations.

Currently, local grammars have been widely applied to investigate discoursal or pragmatic functions, including Su (2017) on request (Table 1), and Hunston and Su (2019) on evaluation (Table 2), among many others (e.g., Hunston and Sinclair 2000; Barnbrook 2002; Cheng and Ching 2018; Su and Wei 2018).

Table 1. A local grammar of request (adapted from Su 2017)

Requester	Hinge	Intended action
I	*want*	*to show you something*
I	*would like*	*to propose a toast*

Indicator	Mitigator	Requested action
can you	*please*	*order a cocktail*
will you		*shut up*

Table 2. A local grammar of evaluation (adapted from Hunston and Su 2019)

Evaluator	Hinge	Evaluation	Target
she	*was*	*happy*	*with her achievements*
she	*was*	*angry*	*to find him still with the circus*

Target	Hinge	Evaluation	Specifier
Birmingham	*is*	*famous*	*as home of the industrial revolution*
The Griffins	*were*	*very generous*	*with offers of lifts*

Tables 1 and 2 provide local grammar analyses of speech act utterances, in particular the mapping of local grammar terminologies onto the corresponding syntactic units of an utterance. The examples further illustrate that such analysis can contribute substantially to the delicacy, transparency and adequacy of linguistic description. It is delicate because each syntactic unit of an utterance which has a pragmatic meaning has been analysed using a term that is directly related to its communicative function (e.g., *shut up* in "will you shut up" is analysed as "Requested action"). It is transparent because the terminologies used in a local grammar analysis are context-specific – that is to say, the selection of terminology relies upon the speech act being analysed (e.g., "Requester" and "Requested action" are used to account for requests), as discussed above. It is adequate because utterances that are associated with a given speech act can be analysed systematically using a limited set of local grammar terminologies, as will be further shown in Section 4.

Slightly different from our previous studies (e.g., Su 2017, 2018; Su and Wei 2018) which use local grammars to account for speech act realisations, this study extends local grammars to diachronic speech act analysis. The question thus is: why and how are local grammars useful for diachronic investigations into speech acts? The answer relates to two features of local grammars. The first is that local grammar analyses capture both formal and semantic regularities of speech act realisations. Specifically, local grammar research requires instances associated with the chosen meaning or function to be identified as exhaustive as possible,[1] facilitating the identification of formal realisations of that targeted meaning or function. More importantly, local grammars are a kind of holistic analysis, covering syntactic, semantic and pragmatic aspects, and they thus capture the underlying regularities of speech act realisations. This is an advantage that other approaches may not have. Take apology as an example. Many researchers (e.g., Blum-Kulka et al. [eds] 1989; Aijmer 1996; Deutschmann 2003) have argued that apologies are frequently expressed by a limited set of specific items (e.g., *sorry, apologize/se* and *regret*). While being in full agreement with this argument, what has not been adequately accounted for in previous studies is that different items may be associated with one same semantic pattern or sequence. Examples[2] (1) and (2) are given for the purpose of illustration.

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1. This has also been one of the challenges that local grammar research faces, because not all meaning or function is realised by a limited set of items or recurrent patterns. In the case of speech acts, an even more challenging problem is that not all illocutionary forces in English are realised syntactically or lexicalised, as noted in Vanderveken (2001: 30).

2. Examples used in this study unless otherwise noted are either taken from Su (2017) or Su and Wei (2018), or from COHA.

(1) I apologize for my earlier outburst.

(2) I regret my inability to perfectly describe the other …

Instances like those in Examples (1) and (2) are counted as two different realisations of apology in previous studies: one realised by *apologize* and the other by *regret*. In both, however, an apologiser performs the action of apologising by specifying an offence or by giving a reason. They realise the same semantic pattern and should thus be considered the same realisation, which can be more easily revealed by local grammar analyses than by any other approaches, as shown in Table 3.

Table 3. A local grammar analysis of apology realised by *apologize/se* and *regret*

Apologiser	Apology	Specification
I	*apologize*	*for my earlier outburst*
I	*regret*	*my inability to perfectly describe the other …*

Another scenario is that instances containing one same item may realise different semantic patterns. Take utterances containing *sorry* as an example.

(3) Sorry.

(4) Sorry I'm late.

(5) I'm sorry.

(6) I'm sorry to interrupt.

(7) I'm truly sorry for what happened last night.

In previous studies, Examples (3) to (7) are normally counted as apologies realised by the item *sorry*, which, however, might appear to be over-simplistic. From a local grammar perspective, each of them realises a distinct pattern and, accordingly, each should be considered a distinct realisation of apology, as shown in the set of analyses presented in Table 4.

The two observations that utterances containing different items may realise the same pattern and that utterances containing the same item may realise distinct patterns would suffice to indicate that quantitative information obtained by simply counting instances containing a given item may not be reliable. In consequence, it is necessary and worthwhile to explore alternative methods for the quantification of speech act realisations.

This leads to the discussion of the second feature of local grammar research which appears to make it advantageous for diachronic speech act analysis. That is, local grammars offer a way to quantify, perhaps more reliably, the means by

Table 4. Local grammar analyses of speech act utterances containing *sorry*

Apology
Sorry

Apology	**Specification**
Sorry	*I'm late*

Apologiser	**Hinge**	**Apology**
I	*'m*	*sorry*

Apologiser	**Hinge**	**Apology**	**Specification**
I	*'m*	*sorry*	*to interrupt*

Apologiser	**Hinge**	**Intensifier**	**Apology**	**Specification**
I	*'m*	*truly*	*sorry*	*for what happened last night*

which a meaning can be expressed or a pragmatic function can be performed. This has been noted by Hunston (2002: 178–181) who argues that local grammar research is useful for quantifying the ways of expressing meanings across registers or contexts. The argument is based on the observation that local grammar descriptions are able to capture the underlying semantic regularities of speech act realisations, as discussed above. Once all instances associated with the targeted meaning or function have been identified in a corpus and subsequently analysed from a local grammar perspective, the (local) grammar of that meaning or function can be developed and, accordingly, the frequency of each means or local grammar pattern can be calculated. This has been exemplified by Su (2017, 2018) who, developing local grammars of request and thanking, demonstrates that ways to perform a given speech act can indeed be quantified in local grammar descriptions.

The potential of local grammars in quantifying the means to express a meaning or to perform a function suggests that a local grammar approach is promising for contrastive studies, which, however, has rarely been explored. To my knowledge, only Bednarek (2007) has attempted to do so. She investigates evaluative language used in broadsheets and tabloids, and finds that differences between the two are more likely to be revealed by the frequency of evaluative

patterns than the function of these patterns. Since diachronic speech act analysis may be viewed as a kind of contrastive study across time (Jucker and Taavitsainen 2000, 2008a), being able to quantify speech act realisations would certainly facilitate diachronic investigations into speech acts. The upshot of the discussion, then, is that a local grammar approach would contribute to a more systematic and detailed investigation into the diachronic development or change of the ways by which a given speech act can be realised.

To recapitulate, local grammars capture the underlying semantic regularities of language in use, thereby contributing to a more comprehensive description of speech act realisations. This further suggests that local grammars are a useful way to quantify the means by which a specific pragmatic function can be performed, facilitating a more reliable quantification of speech act realisations across time. These are important, because diachronic speech act analysis is generally based on the assumption that the core of pragmatic functions is similar across languages or across the history of one language; however, their realisations differ (Jucker and Taavitsainen 2008b: 233) and changes in the frequency of different realisations may suggest changes in social cultures. It is in these respects that I argue that a local grammar approach can be useful for diachronic speech act analysis.

For the purpose of demonstrating the proposed methodology, this study traces the diachronic development of apology. Apology is defined here as a speech act performed by an apologiser, who has done something annoying or damaging or violated accepted social norms, to restore equilibrium and social harmony (cf. Aijmer 1996; Bella 2014). The reason for focusing on this speech act is that apology expressions have been shown to be highly routinised, which "makes apologies particularly suitable for a corpus-based study because only conventionalized expressions are retrievable from large databases" (Jucker and Taavitsainen 2008b: 242). Aijmer (1996: 84), for example, notes that "[a]pologies are generally made up of a small repertoire of relatively fixed expressions representing verbs (*apologize, excuse, pardon*), adjectives (*sorry, afraid*) and nouns (*pardon*) and their expansions, modifications, etc." Deutschmann (2003: 36) observes that apologies tend to be expressed by a limited set of easily identifiable routine formulae. In a similar vein, Leech (2014: 124) argues that "[a] great deal of apologising is done by means of syntactically condensed formulaic devices". Su and Wei (2018) further show that key terms, including *afraid, apologize, apology, excuse, forgive, pardon, regret* and *sorry*, are routinely used to make apologies and that these key terms are useful for the identification of apology expressions in corpora. Although theoretically it is possible to apologise without saying, for example, *sorry*, *excuse me* or *pardon (me)*, studies have shown that this is rarely the case in English (e.g., Deutschmann 2003; Su and Wei 2018). This indicates that searching these specific items would yield a high hit-rate of apology expressions.

In addition, Jucker and Taavitsainen (2008b: 229) note that to their knowledge "nobody has attempted to trace the historical development of apologies or compare their realizations across time". Their study still appears to be the only one as at the time of writing which has investigated apology diachronically. This, on the one hand, indicates the great relevance of their study to this research, and on the other hand, the necessity to further explore apology in the history of English. For the reference of subsequent discussion, the major findings of Jucker and Taavitsainen's (2008b) study are summarised below.

- Apology in the earlier periods of the English language was less routinised and more explicit.
- Apology in the Renaissance data is more frequently embedded in complex forms (e.g., *I beseech, I pray*) and usually followed by an explanation or reason, whereas it is often one-word utterances of the form *sorry* or *pardon* in Present-day English, as shown in Deutschmann (2003).
- There is a change from addressee-centred apologies (i.e., those seeking forgiveness or generosity from the offended) to more speaker-centred apologies (i.e., those taking responsibility for an offence by explicitly saying "(I'm) sorry…"), suggesting a shift from dominating positive politeness culture in earlier periods to a higher level of negative politeness culture nowadays.

It is hoped that, apart from offering new methodological insights into diachronic speech act analysis in general, this study can also to some extent contribute to the diachronic investigation into apology by testing the observations drawn in Jucker and Taavitsainen (2008b) or by triangulating findings obtained by different methods.

3. Corpus and data retrieval

To demonstrate the proposed local grammar approach to diachronic speech act analysis, I draw on data from the sample of the Corpus of Historical American English (hereafter COHA-sample). COHA-sample contains 1,144 texts and has approximately 3.8 million tokens. The reasons for using COHA-sample are as follows. First, COHA is a genre-balanced corpus of historical English, containing text types include fiction, magazine, news and non-fiction, and "its genre and subgenre balance stays almost identical from decade to decade" (Davies 2012a: 161). This is also the case for COHA-sample (although it should be borne in mind that the genres might have shifted). Second, COHA has a consecutive time span, starting from the 1810s and ending in the 2000s, which helps to avoid one of the issues discussed in the Introduction. Third, although most apology

expressions can be identified by searching specific lexical items, the instances extracted thereby have to be manually examined so as to improve precision (i.e., instances identified have the targeted illocutionary force). This suggests that it would be practical to limit the data to a manageable size.[3] It is perhaps worth noting that, since the aim of this study is primarily methodological, restricting the investigation to COHA-sample would not be problematic. In addition, the use of COHA-sample relates to its availability. COHA-sample is freely downloadable,[4] so that everyone can have a full access to it[5] and can test or replicate the current investigation. Extending the proposed local grammar approach to investigate the diachronic development of other speech acts would be particularly welcome and, I argue, worthwhile.

Since speech acts such as thanking and apology are characteristic of spoken language (Aijmer 1996), the use of written data to investigate apology may seem to be questionable. However, I argue that using written texts as the data is justifiable for this study and studies alike in general. This is because, as noted in Taavitsainen and Fitzmaurice (2007: 18), "[a] prerequisite for the conduct of historical pragmatics is the acceptance of written texts as legitimate data". Furthermore, this is also because it is hardly possible to get recorded spoken data in earlier periods. Jucker and Taavitsainen (2008b: 232) similarly point out that:

> In a diachronic analysis such research tools [discourse completion tasks, role-play] are out of the question. We have to rely on written evidence and we cannot elicit specific realizations of speech acts under laboratory conditions as it were. Thus a historical analysis necessarily has to rely on corpus data.

In order to facilitate the diachronic investigation, I divided COHA-sample into four periods of fifty years each. Table 5 gives the meta-information of each sub-corpora.

Turning now to the identification of apology expressions in COHA-sample. There are generally two methods for identifying speech act instances – that is, manual examination of small corpora and computerised searches of large corpora (Taavitsainen and Jucker 2008: 9). Manual identification is obviously an option. Kohnen (2008), for example, advocates what he terms the genre-based empirical approach to identify speech act instances. He suggests that it is useful to examine manually a corpus of smaller size to identify all types of prototypical strategies or realisations of one particular speech act in a given text type (though

3. For example, the search of *sorry* in COHA returns 39,385 hits; it is clearly quite challenging to analyse so many hits manually.

4. See: https://www.corpusdata.org/formats.asp.

5. Researchers have to purchase the data to get a full access to COHA.

Table 5. Meta-information for each period

Period	PE1 (1810s–1850s)		PE2 (1860s–1900s)		PE3 (1910s–1950s)		PE4 (1960s–2000s)	
Genre	**No. texts**	**Tokens**	**No. texts**	**Tokens**	**No. texts**	**Tokens**	**No. texts**	**Tokens**
Fiction	9	171,747	15	704,765	21	531,430	63	595,203
Magazine	15	161,273	31	180,541	240	286,832	300	310,377
News	/	/	73	53,199	181	138,460	170	182,004
Non-fiction	3	190,617	3	190,260	4	113,876	16	166,408
Total	**27**	**523,637**	**122**	**1,128,765**	**446**	**1,070,598**	**549**	**1,253,992**

he also argues that the identified strategies can be used to compose an inventory of manifestations or a list of search terms which can be further employed to search and identify instances of speech acts in a larger corpus). Although manual examination has the advantage of identifying comprehensively and reliably the realisations of a given speech act, "this procedure is extremely time-consuming" (Kohnen 2015: 64) and "the complete coverage of manifestations is often outweighed by the restrictions in terms of corpus size and, therefore, representativeness" (Kohnen 2015: 65).

The alternative method, which has been more widely used, is to search specific items or recurrent patterns (i.e., the so-called illocutionary force indicating devices) by which a given speech act is routinely realised. For example, Deutschmann (2003) and Su and Wei (2018) use a pre-determined list of items to retrieve instances of apology in corpora. Other studies which also use this method include, for example, Aijmer (1996) on apologies and offers, and Su (2017, 2018) on requests and thanking. This method is quite robust and effective to identify speech act instances in larger corpora because most speech acts have been shown to the realised by a limited set of lexical items or recurrent patterns (Aijmer 1996; Jucker 2009). However, it has to be mentioned that this method has some shortcomings, among which one is that "these investigations must rely on the fixed and routinised character of speech acts. If speech acts are not standardised to such an extent, they risk missing the more indirect or uncommon manifestations and thus cannot cover the 'hidden manifestations'" (Kohnen 2015: 64). This suggests that there is still no method currently available to identify effectively and reliably all instances of speech acts in corpora.

In this study, I attempt to identify apology expressions by searching specific items, while being aware that some instances (probably a small number) may be left out. The rationale for using this method is that, as Jucker and Taavitsainen (2008b: 233) note, even if the search of a pre-determined list of apology items only "retrieves a subset of all apologies, it is likely to be a fairly substantial subset, and we believe that it is a very important subset". Following Deutschmann (2003) and Su and Wei (2018), I use the items listed in Table 6 to first search and identify automatically apology expressions in COHA-sample. I then manually examine all the extracted instances to make sure that all remaining instances have the illocutionary force of apologising and thus qualify for the subsequent local grammar analysis.

Since each sub-corpus differs in size, it is necessary to normalise the frequency of each item so that the quantitative information can be more informative and reliable. The equation for normalising the frequency is given below.

$$F(\text{normed}) = F(\text{raw})/\text{Tokens} \times 1{,}000{,}000$$

The quantitative information, both raw and normalised frequency, of each item in each period is given in Table 6.

Table 6. Quantitative information for each item in COHA-sample

Period	PE1 (1810s–1850s)		PE2 (1860s–1900s)		PE3 (1910s–1950s)		PE4 (1960s–2000s)	
Item	**Raw**	**Normed**	**Raw**	**Normed**	**Raw**	**Normed**	**Raw**	**Normed**
sorry	10	19.10	70	62.01	77	71.92	111	88.52
regret	8	15.28	8	7.09	8	7.47	5	3.99
forgive	4	7.64	19	16.83	7	6.54	7	5.58
apology/ies	1	1.91	1	0.89	1	0.93	/	/
apologize/ise	/	/	6	5.32	3	2.80	2	1.59
pardon	6	11.46	27	23.92	15	14.01	20	15.95
excuse	2	3.82	8	7.09	9	8.41	15	11.96
afraid	4	7.64	30	26.58	9	8.41	10	7.97
Total	**35**	**66.84**	**169**	**149.72**	**129**	**120.49**	**170**	**135.57**

As shown in Table 6, there has been an increasing use of the two basic terms *sorry* and *excuse*, whereas the use of performative verbs such as *regret* and *apologize/ise* is generally decreasing. This would suggest that apology becomes more routinised over time. Su and Wei (2018) observe that, in addition to making apologies to the offended by expressing remorse or taking responsibility, another way to apologise is to seek forgiveness from the addressee. This is typically realised by expressions containing performative verbs such as *forgive* (e.g., "forgive my strong language") and *pardon* (e.g., "pardon me for calling you such"). Seeking forgiveness from the offended may be considered more face-threatening from the perspective of politeness theory (Brown and Levinson 1987; Leech 2014), because it requires the addressee's generosity or forbearance for an offence. The observation that *forgive* in particular is used relatively infrequently in PE3 and PE4 than in PE1 and PE2, then, might suggest that modern society is becoming politer (cf. Jucker and Taavitsainen 2008b). To test these observations and to further explore the diachronic development of apology, in the following sections I present the analyses of apology expressions in a more systematic and principled manner and discuss the results.

4. A local grammar analysis of apology

This section demonstrates the local grammar analyses of apology expressions, aiming to further illustrate how to analyse speech act utterances from a local grammar perspective and to provide data for the subsequent diachronic investigation. Based on our own research (Su and Wei 2018), the terminologies listed in Table 7 are adapted for analysing apology expressions identified in COHA-sample.

Having extracted apology expressions and identified the local grammar terminologies within the specific context of apologising, the next task for the researcher, then, is to map the terminologies onto corresponding formal or structural elements. Following Su and Wei (2018), this study divides strategies for apologising into two categories: making apologies to the offended and seeking forgiveness from the offended. For the purpose of illustration, Table 8 presents analyses of instances where apology is typically realised by idiomatic expressions (e.g., "sorry" and "forgive me"), Table 9 analyses where the offence or reason for an apology is specified (e.g., "I apologize for some of the things I've said") and Table 10 analyses where apology is intensified (e.g., "I am exceedingly sorry if I have neglected…").

Table 7. Terminologies for analysing apology (adapted from Su and Wei 2018: 447)

Terminology	Explanation	Example
Apologiser	The one who apologises	***I*** *am sorry.*
Apology	The element that indicates the action of apologising	*I* ***apologize****.*
Forgiveness-seeking	The action of seeking forgiveness	*Please* ***forgive*** *me*
Apologisee	a. to whom the apology is made	*Just apologize to* ***him****.*
	b. from whom the apologiser seeks forgiveness	*Will* ***you*** forgive us?
Intensifier	The element that upgrades the degree of apology or regret	*I am* ***so*** *sorry.*
Specification	The element that specifies the offense/reason for an apology or for forgiveness-seeking	*I am sorry* ***for what I said****. Excuse me for being so bold.*
Hinge	The element that links different functional elements	*I* ***am*** *really sorry about this.*

Table 8a. Apology construed as "Apology"

Apology
Sorry
(my) apologies

Table 8b. Apology construed as "Forgiveness-seeking"

Forgiveness-seeking
Pardon me
Forgive me

Table 9a. Apology construed as "Apologiser – Apology – Specification"

Apologiser	Apology	Specification
I	*apologize*	*for some of the things I've said*
I	*regret*	*that you have been troubled by a mistake*

Table 9b. Apology construed as "Forgiveness-seeking – Specification"

Forgiveness-seeking	Specification
Forgive	*my petulance*
Pardon	*my rudeness*

Table 10a. Apology construed as "Intensifier – Forgiveness-seeking"

Intensifier	Forgiveness-seeking
Please	*forgive me*
Do	*forgive me*

Table 10b. Apology construed as "Apologiser – Hinge – Intensifier – Apology – Specification"

Apologiser	Hinge	Intensifier	Apology	Specification
I	*'m*	*very sincerely*	*sorry*	*that you should have unexpectedly seen me*
I	*'m*	*awfully*	*sorry*	*for Kenny mixed up in all of this*

Tables 8 to 10 further illustrate what is meant by stating that local grammar analyses involve the mapping of pragmatic terminologies onto formal elements (i.e., each syntactic element is analysed using a term that is directly related to its discoursal or communicative function), and how a local grammar analysis proceeds (see Su [2017, 2018] and Su and Wei [2018] for more exemplifications of local grammar analyses of speech act utterances).

This study identified more variants of local grammar patterns of apology than Su and Wei (2018).[6] Thus to save space all the patterns identified and an illustrative example for each pattern are given in Table 11. For the sake of clarity, the patterns are grouped into five sets, according to the number of the terminologies needed for each of them.

6. The main reason for this may be that Su and Wei (2018) use scripted TV dialogues as the data, whereas this study is based on data drawn from written texts.

Table 11. Local grammar patterns of apology

	Local grammar pattern		Example
Set 1	PA1	Apology	"Sorry"
	PA2	Forgiveness-seeking	"Forgive me"
	PA3	Apology – Specification	"Sorry about shouting"
	PA4	Apology – Apologisee	"Sorry, Mister Potter"
	PA5	Forgiveness-seeking – Specification	"Forgive my rudeness"
	PA6	Forgiveness-seeking – Apologisee	"Forgive me, my boy"
Set 2	PA7	Intensifier – Apology	"Really sorry"
	PA8	Apologiser – Apology	"I apologize"
	PA9	Apologisee – Forgiveness-seeking	"God forgive me"
	PA10	Apologiser – Forgiveness-seeking	"I beg your pardon"
	PA11	Intensifier – Forgiveness-seeking	"Please forgive me"
	PA12	Intensifier – Forgiveness-seeking – Specification	"Please forgive my rude speeches"
	PA13	Intensifier – Apology – Specification	"So sorry to have missed you"
	PA14	Intensifier – Apologisee – Forgiveness-seeking	"Please, Lydia, forgive me"
	PA15	Apologiser – Apology – Specification	"I apologize for some of the things I've said"
Set 3	PA16	Apologiser – Apology – Apologisee	"I apologize, Alvin"
	PA17	Apologiser – Forgiveness-seeking – Specification	"I beg your pardon for having mistaken you"
	PA18	Apologisee – Forgiveness-seeking – Specification	"God forgive my dastardly presence"
	PA19	Apologiser – Forgiveness-seeking – Apologisee	"I beg pardon, Judge Baker"
	PA20	Apologiser – Hinge – Apology	"I'm sorry"
	PA21	Apologiser – Hinge – Apology – Apologisee	"I am sorry, Jack"
Set 4	PA22	Apologisee – Apologiser – Hinge – Apology	"Tono, I'm sorry"
	PA23	Intensifier – Apologiser – Apology – Specification	"Let me apologize for my asperity"

Table 11. *(continued)*

	Local grammar pattern		Example
	PA24	Apologiser – Hinge – Apology – Specification	"I'm sorry I was rude"
	PA25	Apologiser – Hinge – Intensifier – Apology	"I'm truly sorry"
	PA26	Apologiser – Intensifier – Apology – Specification	"I deeply regret I must so soon leave Oakland"
	PA27	Apologiser – Hinge – Apology – Apologisee – Specification	"We own an apology to the reader and to …"
	PA28	Apologiser – Hinge – Intensifier – Apology – Specification	"I am sincerely sorry for that"
Set 5	PA29	Apologiser – Hinge – Intensifier – Apology – Apologisee	"I am very sorry, Medline"
	PA30	Apologiser – Apology – Intensifier – Apologisee – Specification	"I apologize most humbly to you and to Lady Victoria for having startled you"

5. Results and discussion

Based on the analyses, the number of each pattern is counted in the four periods. Quantitative information is given in Table 12.

We are now in a position to discuss some observations that can be drawn from the analyses, though it should be stressed that the restriction of data to COHA-sample indicates that any observations discussed below need to be further tested through larger-scale investigation. Examining those patterns which at least have four occurrences in COHA-sample suggests that there are patterns increasing and/or emerging, patterns decreasing and/or disappearing, and those fluctuating as well. To note briefly, the distinction between increasing patterns and emerging ones is tentatively made on the basis of whether there has been any occurrence in earlier period(s); and similarly, the distinction between decreasing patterns and disappearing ones is made on the basis of whether there is any occurrence in later period(s). Fluctuating patterns are those which do not show a clear trend of either increasing or decreasing. Patterns belonging to each category are discussed in turn.

Six patterns are shown to be increasingly used or emerging (Figure 1). Specifically, two patterns are observed being increasingly used to make apologies: "Apologiser – Hinge – Apology" and "Apologiser – Hinge – Apology – Apologisee". The two patterns are quite similar, being realised by instances containing the formu-

Table 12. Quantitative information of each pattern in each period in COHA-sample

			PE1		PE2		PE3		PE4	
			Raw	Normed	Raw	Normed	Raw	Normed	Raw	Normed
Set 1	PA1	16	/	/	/	/	5	4.67	11	8.77
	PA2	52	4	7.64	19	16.83	10	9.34	19	15.15
	PA3	12	/	/	1	0.89	4	3.74	7	5.58
	PA4	5	/	/	/	/	/	/	5	3.99
	PA5	31	5	9.55	11	9.75	4	3.74	11	8.77
	PA6	18	1	1.91	10	8.86	4	3.74	3	2.39
Set 2	PA7	5	/	/	3	2.66	1	0.93	1	0.80
	PA8	2	/	/	/	/	1	0.93	1	0.80
	PA9	9	1	1.91	3	2.66	3	2.80	2	1.60
	PA10	17	/	/	3	2.66	10	9.34	4	3.19
	PA11	2	/	/	1	0.89	/	/	1	0.80
	PA12	1	/	/	1	0.89	/	/	/	/
	PA13	2	/	/	1	0.89	1	0.93	/	/
	PA14	1	/	/	/	/	/	/	1	0.80
	PA15	23	3	5.73	6	5.32	8	7.47	6	4.78
Set 3	PA16	1	/	/	/	/	1	0.93	/	/
	PA17	1	/	/	1	0.89	/	/	/	/
	PA18	3	/	/	2	1.77	/	/	1	0.80
	PA19	4	1	1.91	3	2.66	/	/	/	/
	PA20	80	1	1.91	4	3.54	30	28.02	45	35.89
	PA21	25	1	1.91	3	2.66	9	8.41	12	9.57
	PA22	4	/	/	/	/	/	/	4	3.19
Set 4	PA23	1	/	/	1	0.89	/	/	/	/
	PA24	114	10	19.10	55	48.73	20	18.68	29	23.13
	PA25	36	/	/	21	18.60	10	9.34	5	3.99
	PA26	8	5	9.55	3	2.66	/	/	/	/
	PA27	2	1	1.91	1	0.89	/	/	/	/
Set 5	PA28	19	2	3.82	12	10.63	4	3.74	1	0.80
	PA29	8	/	/	3	2.66	4	3.74	1	0.80
	PA30	1	/	/	1	0.89	/	/	/	/

laic sequence "I'm sorry". The difference lies in that in the former pattern the addressee is not specified whereas in the latter the addressee is specified. The observation that these patterns are realised by ritualised expressions provides additional evidence to support the argument that apologies are more conventionalised in Present-day English (Deutschmann 2003; Jucker and Taavitsainen 2008b).

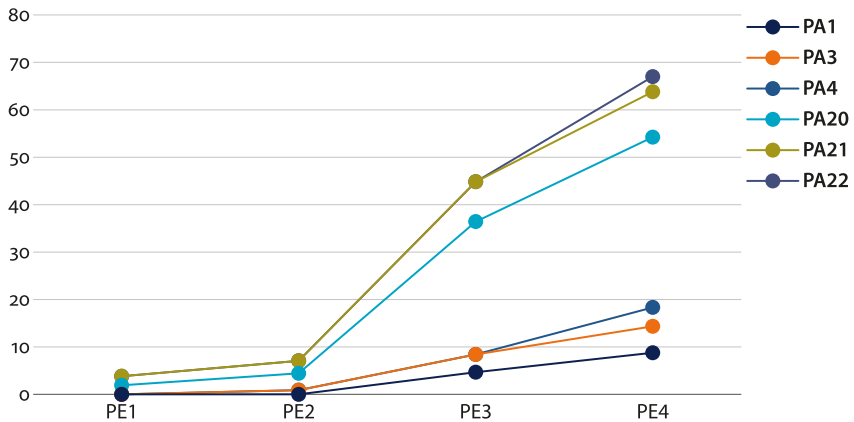

Figure 1. Patterns used increasingly or emerging in COHA-sample

In COHA-sample, four patterns are observed to be emerging: "Apology", "Apology – Apologisee", "Apology – Specification" and "Apologisee – Apologiser – Hinge – Apology". Of particular interest to note is that the pattern "Apology" does not occur until the 1910s. While this of course does not mean that people in the 1810s to the 1900s apologise less, this suggests that other apology strategies might be preferred. As shown in Table 12, the equivalent pattern, "Forgiveness-seeking" (and also "Forgiveness-seeking – Specification"), does occur in the first period. Furthermore, data presented in Table 7 may suggest another possible explanation for the less frequent use of "Apology" and "Apology – Specification" in earlier periods. Since the typical realisations of "Apology" and "Apology – Specification" are *sorry* and *sorry for/about/that/to-inf.* and "Forgiveness-seeking" is typically realised by the performative verb *forgive*, the less frequent use of the two patterns in the first period may be accounted for by the observation that *forgive* is used relatively more frequently in the 1810s to the 1850s.

Moreover, the observation that the pattern "Apology" is only identified in the 1900s might have two implications. One is related to social norms, that is, apology in Present-day English becomes more ritual and routinised, which is largely consistent with Jucker and Taavitsainen's (2008b) observation, as noted in Section 2. The other is methodological. Specifically, this points to one of the

advantages of local grammar analysis. Compared with a simple or surface examination of speech act realisations, local grammars can contribute to a more comprehensive description of speech act utterances, especially in the sense that local grammar analyses capture their underlying semantic regularities which may otherwise not be easily observable. That is, because *sorry*, by which "Apology" is realised, has also been used in earlier periods, a simple count of instances containing *sorry* cannot reveal that an isolated *sorry* is used to make apologies only quite recently. Although further investigation is needed to test whether this is true in the history of the English language, this could serve as a good example to illustrate the argument that local grammars offer a way by which speech act realisations can be more reliably quantified.

Let us turn now to patterns that are decreasing or disappearing. These patterns show a more complex picture: they were used increasingly from the first period (PE1) to the second (PE2), and then used decreasingly in the subsequent periods (PE3 and PE4). These are regarded as patterns which are used decreasingly or disappearing because they generally show a trend of declining, despite an increase from PE1 to PE2. Specifically, the following four patterns are observed to be used less frequently period by period: "Forgiveness-seeking – Apologisee", "Intensifier – Apology", "Apologiser – Hinge – Intensifier – Apology" and "Apologiser – Hinge – Intensifier – Apology – Specification", as shown in Figure 2. The decreasing use of the pattern "Forgiveness-seeking – Apologisee" may be attributed to the fact that explicit use of performative verbs such as *forgive* generally declines, which is also true for COHA, as shown in Figure 3. This is consistent with Bergner's (1992) and Kohnen's (2000) finding that explicit use of speech act verbs is less common in Present-day English than in earlier periods.

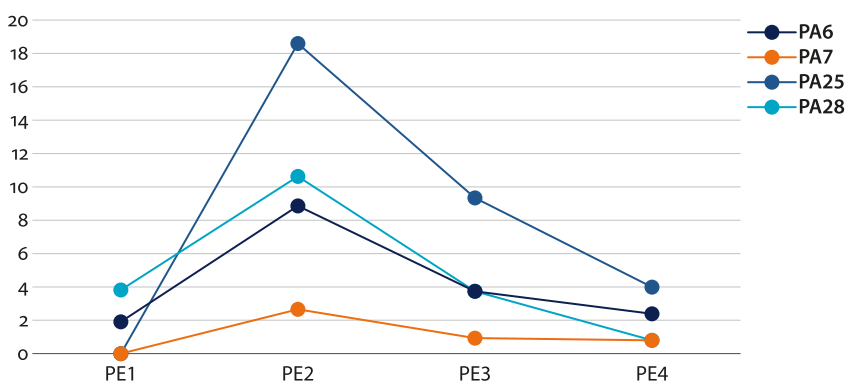

Figure 2. Patterns used decreasingly in COHA-sample

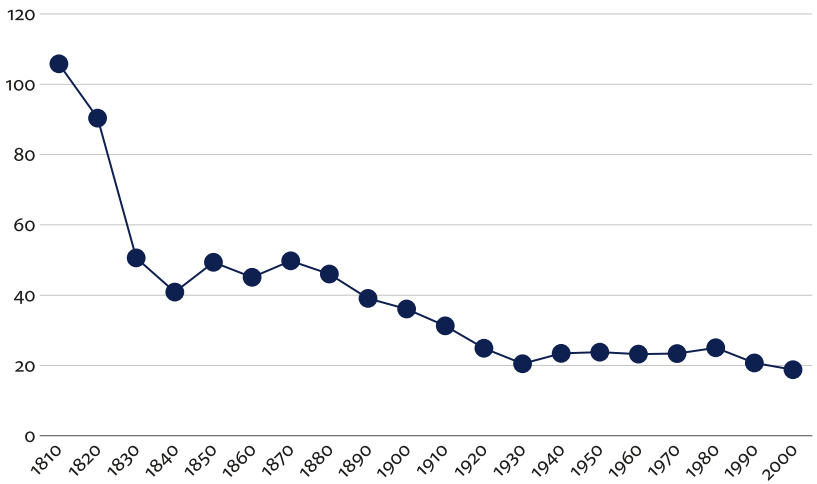

Figure 3. Normalised frequency chart of FORGIVE in COHA

One common feature that is shared by the other three patterns is that they involve an element which is labelled "Intensifier". Since we usually use some strategies to make our apologies sincerer or what we have mistakenly done less offensive, the observation that patterns involving "Intensifier" are used decreasingly seems to suggest that in modern society we become less polite. This, however, may not be the case. The reason for the declining use of intensifiers might be related to social development (i.e., the social distance between individuals is reduced). In a similar vein, Leech (2014: 299), arguing against the view that politeness is declining, notes that:

> If there is a relatively new development, it is that in communication, not only vertical distance but horizontal distance has been radically reduced. That is, in the "egalitarian society" of today, everyone is equal and can claim instant solidarity with other individuals.

As such, utterances such as "sorry" and "excuse me", without specifying the offence or intensifying the degree of remorse, would work as an apology in daily conversation.

No instances are found realising patterns "Apologiser – Forgiveness-seeking – Apologisee" and "Apologiser – Intensifier – Apology – Specification" in the last two periods, which suggests that these two patterns are disappearing (see Figure 4). Since the pattern "Apologiser – Intensifier – Apology – Specification" is typically realised by performative verbs such as *apologise* and *regret* (as in "I heartily regret that any idle assumption of importance on my part"), the decline of this pattern may be accounted for by the observation that the two performative

verbs are used relatively less frequently in the twentieth century, as shown in Table 6.

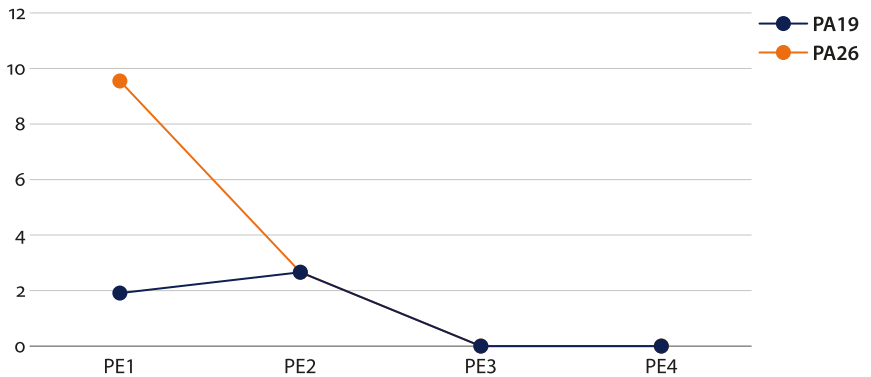

Figure 4. Patterns disappearing in COHA-sample

Finally, there are five patterns which do not clearly show an increasing or decreasing tendency; rather, they are fluctuating, as shown in Figure 5. These patterns are: "Forgiveness-seeking", "Forgiveness-seeking – Specification", "Apologisee – Forgiveness-seeking", "Apologiser – Apology – Specification" and "Apologiser – Hinge – Apology – Specification". For "Forgiveness-seeking", it is fluctuating because it can be realised by idiomatic expressions including "excuse me", "forgive me" and "pardon (me)", in particular the observation that the performative verb *excuse* is increasingly used whereas *forgive* is used decreasingly. For the other three patterns, it is noticed that they involve an element labelled "Specification". This would suggest that people always appear to be willing to specify the offence they apologise for or to give a reason for an apology; what varies is how frequently people do so, which depends on various factors "such as the severity of the offense and the degrees of power and social distance existing between interlocutors" (Bella 2014: 682).

Furthermore, Jucker and Taavitsainen (2008b: 241–243) argued a change from addressee-centred apologies (i.e., seeking forgiveness from the offended), to more speaker-centred apologies (i.e., taking responsibility by expressing their own remorse or regret). The current investigation does not appear to support this observation, because most patterns containing the terminology for "Forgiveness-seeking" are fluctuating, rather than showing a consistent trend of either increasing or decreasing over time. Thus, the observation made in previous studies that there is a development of a higher level of negative politeness in British culture (e.g., Kopytko 1995; Jucker and Taavitsainen 2008b) seems to be at odds with what happens in American society. A caveat, however, should be

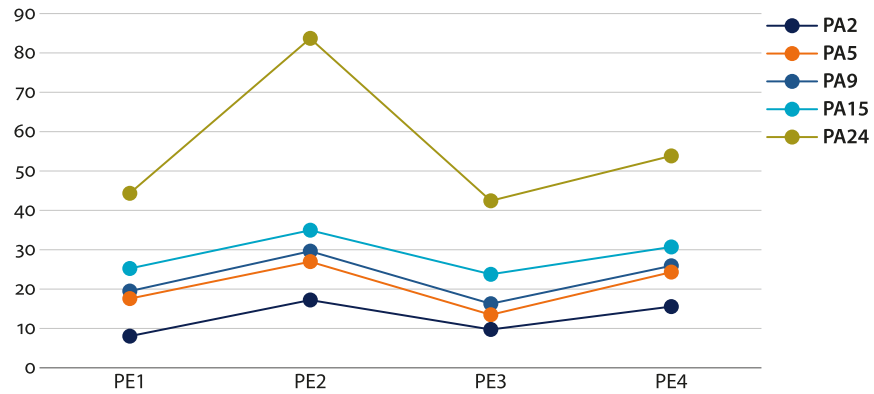

Figure 5. Patterns fluctuating in COHA-sample

mentioned that politeness is a complex social phenomenon that is dependent on factors such as social distance and power relations between interlocutors. A comprehensive characterisation of politeness requires more thorough investigation into associated "speech events" in specific social-cultural contexts (cf. Leech 2014).

Based on the above discussion, we can summarise the main observations about the diachronic development of apology that can be made based on this local grammar investigation, though it should be stressed again that these observations are restricted to COHA-sample. The investigation shows that apologies become more routinised, being frequently realised by simple utterances such as "(I'm) sorry", "forgive/excuse me" and "pardon (me)". Secondly, the decreasing use of intensifiers (e.g., "terribly/awfully/really sorry" and "sincerely apologise/ize") suggests that the social distance between individuals in modern society has been reduced, with greater equality and more claims of solidarity with other individuals. Thirdly, people are willing to specify the offence or reason for an apology, and this has not changed over time.

6. Conclusion

Taavitsainen and Fitzmaurice (2007: 29) suggest that "a step forward [in historical pragmatics] can be taken by raising the level of awareness of methodological problems" and that "[r]eliable methods are worth striving for" (Taavitsainen and Fitzmaurice 2007: 30). Responding to this suggestion, this study has been mainly methodological. Situated within the field of historical pragmatics, the study proposes a local grammar approach to facilitate diachronic speech act analysis, which is demonstrated by tracing apology in the history of American English. The

current investigation, though the data has been restricted to COHA-sample, should have amassed sufficient evidence to show the feasibility and usefulness of a local grammar approach to diachronic speech act analysis. It is particularly noteworthy that each unit of speech act utterances which has a pragmatic meaning has been systematically accounted for in local grammar analyses, which helps to capture the underlying semantic regularities of speech act realisations. This further indicates that the quantitative information obtained through local grammar analyses is more reliable than that obtained through traditional approaches. The point, then, is that analysing speech act utterances from a local grammar perspective facilitates the quantification of the ways in which a given speech act can be realised, which in turn offers a way to compare speech act realisations across time, thereby contributing to diachronic speech act studies.

The main challenge that the proposed method faces, like all kinds of corpus-based speech act studies, relates to the identification of speech act instances (see also Su 2017). Corpus-based speech act studies often take a pre-determined list of lexical items or recurrent patterns as the starting point in identifying instances of speech acts. The major drawback of such research is that "the identification of speech acts [...] is limited to only the forms and phrases that the researcher predicts will carry pragmatic meaning and cannot account for the full range of linguistic forms that are possible, specifically those that the researcher has not predicted to include pragmatic meaning" (Garcia 2015: 29). Consequently, computerised searches may leave undetected speech act utterances which do not contain such conventionalised forms. This suggests that greater efforts are needed to explore alternative methods which are robust and efficient to extract more exhaustively and reliably instances of speech acts in corpora.

The proposed local grammar approach, nevertheless, offers a new method for diachronic speech act studies. More research using the proposed approach to investigate diachronically speech acts would be particularly desirable and valuable, and COHA would be a useful resource for such investigations. Research in this tradition can not only contribute substantially to our understanding of the diachronic development of speech acts, but also that, as Taavitsainen and Jucker (2008: 8) note, "the diachronic development of speech acts can reveal the formulation of cultural scripts".

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